



CUG Saved Rs 20,000 For Bangalore-based IT Firm

Closed User Group (CUG) is a facility most telecom operators offer companies that run up fairly huge telephone bills. For a nominal fee, this service lets a fixed number of people make calls at a reduced rate from the same company.

SVC Bank along with the VoIP facility got an internal CUG, which resulted in a substantial reduction of communication costs. They also got an external CUG for their executives spread across Maharashtra from Orange, a Mumbai-based cellular service provider.

CUGs met with success at Select Technologies, Bangalore. Six months ago, the company faced burgeoning telephone bills. Despite support partners across the world, its 17 Indian branch offices were found making the maximum number of calls.

This prompted A Santosh, Manager, Finance and Operations, to switch to Airtel's CUG service. With a basic tariff of Rs 599 per person and a call charge of 30 paise per minute, 55 phones became a part of the CUG.

The result: Savings of at least Rs 20,000 per month.

Column Ad

deals with support requests from other branches.

The MS Exchange server is also used to create a common bulletin-board service for meetings and other programmes. On the internal network, digital signatures used to authenticate e-mail-certificates are issued inhouse. All this is part of an effort to create a seamless business communication network.

Says Mankikar, "Its implementation is not important, but that it is working well is." However, some holes need to be plugged—communication on the move, for instance.

For that, he says, SVC bank uses a Closed User Group (CUG) of mobile users with Orange as the service provider. The CUG and the internal data network are maintained as separate entities, which are as distinct as external PSTN and GSM networks, to ensure that internal security is not compromised.

Other than that, the bank also uses an FTP server that holds support documentation for the implementation of VoIP.

It has been designed to ensure that the support system runs smoothly in the unlikely event that the links to the head office go down, and at the same time, reduce traffic to and from the Head Office servers.

The Results Are Showing

The past two years saw SVC Bank migrating to the paperless office in a phased manner. The migration for most of the intra-location organisations is complete.

In the pipeline are projects to set up a service using which

employees can log in, apply for leave and check the status of their applications.

They also plan to implement Microsoft's Unified Messaging System (UMS), which aims to provide unified messaging based on Windows NT and Windows 2000 as the operating systems, along with Microsoft Exchange Server as well as Windows CE.

This allows users access to a single inbox containing e-mail, voicemail, fax and paged messages via a phone or another device.

For SVC bank, this means that employees can manage their e-mail, voicemail, fax and page messages via the same interface they use to search the Web or an intranet, and access corporate data and applications.

All this is to ensure that network costs remain the same as they increase their leverage on existing systems, says Mankikar as his colleague, Jayavanti K Hattangdi, Deputy General Manager, Operations, SVC Bank calls up a branch office on her IP phone.

He points out that this call is being routed to Pune. Back in his office, he shows us the system that generates warnings and e-mails that contain information such as status reports, coming from the call manager, thus giving a bird's-eye view of the links to all branches and ATMs.

SVC bank seems to be plugging its corporate communication gaps swiftly. "My aim is to change the way people perceive co-operative banks," he says. Innovation, it seems, need not come from far above. ■

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